

GAO PROBES UFO

1947 Roswell, N.M., crash an unsolved mystery

By William Claiborne
The Washington Post

WASHINGTON — Where television's "Unsolved Mysteries" has tried and failed, the General Accounting Office is unafraid to venture.

At the request of Rep. Steven Schiff, R-N.M., Congress' investigative branch has launched a study to determine whether the government covered up a story alleging that the bodies of alien space voyagers were removed from a crashed flying saucer found near Roswell, N.M., in 1947.

After the purported crash of the spacecraft, the bodies of the extra-terrestrial visitors were said by a local undertaker and other conspir-

acy theorists to have been autopsied and then secretly flown to an Air Force base in Ohio.

Even though the "Roswell Incident" has been dismissed repeatedly by the Defense Department as nothing more than UFO fantasizing triggered by the discovery of a downed weather balloon, the GAO has begun searching for documents to prove allegations that the Air Force "suppressed" information sought by Schiff.

Schiff is a member of the House Government Operations Committee, which oversees the GAO.

GAO spokeswoman Laura Kopelson said the office's investigation, first reported in the Albuquerque Journal yesterday, stemmed from a meeting in October between Schiff

and GAO Controller General Charles Bowsher. Schiff complained then that the Defense Department had been "unresponsive" to his inquiries about the 1947 incident.

Kopelson said there was no way of estimating how much the investigation would cost, and that the GAO does not release such information anyway.

Kopelson said Schiff had asked the GAO "to see if there is any evidence that information regarding UFOs had been suppressed" following the Roswell incident.

Schiff, in a telephone interview from Albuquerque, said that last March, after receiving inquiries from "UFO believers" and some

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Roswell residents who were in the military in 1947, he wrote to Defense Secretary Les Aspin asking for more information about the reported spacecraft crash and the alleged disappearance of the aliens' bodies.

The crash of a mysterious object 80 miles northwest of Roswell, which the Air Force later claimed was a weather balloon equipped with a radar-reflecting device, has been the subject of books and remains UFO buffs' greatest riddle. A privately owned museum in Roswell contains a number of documents and photographs purport-

ing to prove the existence of the aliens. It also displays a recreation of the spacecraft surrounded by figures portraying the dead extraterrestrials.

UFO buffs contend the incident marked the beginning of a government conspiracy to suppress evidence of alien life.

Much of the speculation stems from claims by William Haut, a former Air Force public-affairs officer, who said that on July 2, 1947, he was told to prepare a news release reporting that the Air Force had recovered parts of a flying saucer and then was told to change the story to report a weather balloon.

Also, a nurse reportedly told a local funeral home director that she witnessed the autopsies of the spacemen, whom she described as having oversized heads and beetle-like features. The nurse subsequently died in a plane crash.

After the autopsies, conspiracy theorists said the bodies were flown to Fort Worth, Texas, and then to what is now Wright-Patterson Air Force Base in Ohio.

In 1989, NBC's "Unsolved Mysteries" investigated the controversy, which the program's host, Robert Stack, said was unsolved.

Schiff said that after calling Aspin last March to request a Pentagon briefing on the Roswell inci-

dent, he received a call from an Air Force lieutenant colonel who brusquely told him the documents had been turned over to the National Archives.

However, Schiff said, Archive officials told him they did not have the records on Roswell, even though they did have records of "Project Blue Book," a 1969 Air Force study of reported UFO sightings.

That study, Schiff said, did not deal with the Roswell case.

"I was getting pretty upset at all the running around," Schiff said, adding that in his meeting with GAO officials, "they made an offer to help."